

Siberian Taiga

A massive forest on the edge of the Arctic, ruled by conifers, where winter lasts most of the year



The vast boreal forest known as Siberian taiga covers around 2.6 million square miles (6.7 million square km) from the Ural Mountains east to the Pacific Ocean. It stretches from northern Russia's Arctic fringes, where the taiga merges into the tundra, as far south as Mongolia. Like all boreal forests, Siberian taiga is primarily a conifer habitat, beginning as a mixture of spruce, pine, and larch in the west before giving way to unbroken swathes of larch in its eastern Russian and Mongolian reaches.

Changing canopy

In more southerly areas, dense tree growth results in "closed canopy" forests, with little light penetrating to the moss-covered forest floor beneath. However, with increasing distance northward, the forest cover becomes sparser, and lichen replaces moss on the ground. In more temperate parts, dominant conifers become mixed with broadleaf species such as birch, aspen, and willow.

▷ PINPOINTING PREY

The great gray owl mainly eats tiny rodents, which it locates with exceptional hearing—pinpointing them even under snow.



In the east, marsh and bogland support understory shrubs such as cranberry and bilberry, while in the west, poor drainage and permafrost mean such areas are mainly given over to spongy, shallow bogs with no tree cover at all.

Cold climate

Winter in the Siberian taiga lasts six to seven months, with the climate dominated by cold Arctic air. The average temperature range is broad—from -65°F (-54°C) in winter to 70°F (21°C) in summer—but extremes of -76°F (-60°C) and 104°F (40°C) are not uncommon, and the yearly average is below freezing.

The taiga contains **as many trees** as all the rain forests combined



◁ SNOW FOREST

Snow lasts into May in the taiga, returning in September or earlier. However, snow-covered trees serve as an insulator, keeping the ground warmer than the air above the forest.

△ CHANGING TERRAIN

In many parts of the taiga, conifers cluster around rivers, where richer soils offer better growing conditions. Forested sections are divided by mountains at higher elevations.

FROM TAIGA TO TUNDRA

Taiga tree growth varies greatly according to latitude. In southern areas, trees are taller and more closely packed together, but density and height both diminish toward the north. Eventually, only a few small trees survive before the landscape changes entirely from taiga to tundra.

